

RUPAL MAHAJAN

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EDUCATION

Northwestern University Evanston, IL
Ph.D., Social Psychology (Est. 2030) – Advisor: Dr. Dan Molden;
M.S., Social Psychology (Est. 2027)

The Ohio State University Columbus, OH
Bachelor of Science, Psychology – May 2025

RESEARCH SKILLS

Statistical & Computational

- R: linear models, multiple linear regression, multilevel modeling (lme4), data visualization
- SPSS, JASP: quantitative analysis, hypothesis testing
- Qualtrics: survey design, implementation, and data management

Qualitative & Mixed Methods

- Thematic coding of open-ended and audio-recorded data; linguistic abstraction coding of narrative data
- Multimodal data collection: audio recording, physiological measurement (dynamometer), deception protocols

Technical

- Microsoft Office Suite, Google Suite
- Languages: English, Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi, American Sign Language

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant: Developmental Psychology Spring 2026
Northwestern University, Department of Psychology

- Supported instruction through office hours, grading, and student feedback in undergraduate developmental psychology course

Teaching Assistant: Psychological Statistics Winter 2026
Northwestern University, Department of Psychology

- Supported instruction in undergraduate statistics course; held office hours and assisted with grading and student questions on quantitative methods.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Lab Supervisor & Research Coordinator August 2024 – May 2025
Dr. Kentaro Fujita's Motivation and Cognitive Science Lab, The Ohio State University

- Designed research materials, drafted IRB applications, and implemented Qualtrics surveys for studies on self-control, motivation, and bias confrontation.
- Conducted quantitative and qualitative data analysis using R and SPSS, including thematic coding of audio-recorded confrontation interactions.
- Led multimodal data collection using deception protocols, physiological equipment, and audio recording across multiple independent and collaborative studies.
- Trained and supervised a team of Research Assistants in advanced data collection techniques.

- Collaborated with postdoctoral researchers and graduate students to optimize project timeliness and resource management.

Research Assistant

August 2023 – August 2024

Dr. Kentaro Fujita's Motivation and Cognitive Science Lab, The Ohio State University

- Coded and analyzed written responses across studies on goal-pursuit, stereotyping, and prejudice.
- Facilitated data collection using physiological equipment, deception protocols, and survey methodologies.
- Conducted literature reviews to support ongoing projects and identify gaps in existing research.

RESEARCH PROJECTS

Self-Control Strategies and Interpersonal Impressions

Ongoing

- Independent study examining how alignment vs. mismatch between abstinence and moderation self-control strategies shapes interpersonal impressions and affiliation interest toward the strategist.
- Preliminary findings reveal a competence-warmth tradeoff: abstinence strategies boost perceived competence while moderation strategies enhance warmth; scenario variation and moral judgment point to meaningful boundary conditions and mechanisms.
- Designed all study materials; currently managing participant recruitment, data collection, and analysis.

Bias Confrontation as a Goal-Conflict Dilemma

Data Analysis Underway

- Independent study investigating how goal conflict influences decisions to confront bias.
- Led full study lifecycle: design, IRB, materials creation, data collection, cleaning, and preliminary analysis.
- Analyzed confrontation decision-making using quantitative outcomes and thematic coding of confrontation narratives.

Confrontation and Self-Control: Reactions Influencing Confrontation Decisions

Collaborative

- Designed a three-part longitudinal Qualtrics study; collected data as both confederate and experimenter.
- Analyzed suspicion themes and trained research assistants on protocol.

Employee/Customer Perceptions of Companies Withdrawing DEI Support

Collaborative

- Led research design and protocol development; facilitated data collection.
- Developed visual experimental stimuli using the Chicago Face Database and AI-assisted image generation.

Psychological Distance and Construal Level: Current vs. Future Me

Collaborative

- Conducted linguistic abstraction coding of 600+ participant narratives to assess construal level.
- Supervised a team of research assistants in coding procedures.

Mental Representation and Goals

- Collected physiological data using a dynamometer as a behavioral indicator of self-control.

POSTER PRESENTATIONS

- Mahajan, R., Hildebrand, L.K., Kroeper, K.M., & Fujita, K. (April 2025). To speak or stay silent: The role of goal conflict in bias confrontations. Midwestern Psychological Association Conference, Chicago, IL.
- Mahajan, R., Hildebrand, L.K., Kroeper, K.M., & Fujita, K. (February 2025). Bias confrontation as a goal-conflict dilemma. Society for Personality and Social Psychology Preconference, Denver, CO.

MENTORSHIP & SERVICE

Research Mentor: 15 Undergraduate Research Assistants

2025 – Present

Northwestern University, Department of Psychology

- Recruit, train, and supervise 15 undergraduate RAs across multiple active research projects; most notably trained RAs in high-deception confederate protocols for a bias confrontation study, including role-play preparation, in-session procedures, and post-study debriefing.

Secretary, Psychology Graduate Student Council (PGSC)

September 2025 – Present

- Represent the Social Psychology Area in council planning and decision-making; coordinate cross-area communication and organize community-building events for graduate students.

Intern, Buckeye Clinic Addiction Treatment Center

April – August 2023

- Facilitated daily group counseling sessions for inpatient opioid recovery patients; supported personalized case management and HIPAA-compliant data recording.

HONORS & AWARDS

- Psychology Department Student Research Funding Grant, Northwestern University — \$1,360 (2025)
- Undergraduate Research Scholarship, The Ohio State University — \$3,200 (Spring 2025)

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

- Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP)
- Midwestern Psychological Association